

ZEERBOX · CALCULATION NOTE

ZeerBox sizing and first-principles checks

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DOCUMENT CONTROL

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REVISION HISTORY

Version	Date	Author	Change
0.2	2026-09-25	Amish Chadha	Recommendations accepted by Amish (DDR-002). 150 mm pad, dry rice husk cavity fill, R3 at 80 %; all figures rerun
0.1	2026-09-25	Amish Chadha	First TRL 3 sizing note (psychrometrics, fan and pad operating point, heat balance, humidity, off-design weather, energy, water, electrical, structure, cost) against every requirement

ZeerBox sizing and first-principles checks

On paper the store cools as the concept claims, with margin on temperature and humidity close to the relaxed target. This version (v0.2) applies the decisions in ZBX-DDR-002: a 150 mm pad in place of 100 mm, a dry rice husk cavity fill in place of wet sand, and R3 relaxed from 85 % to 80 %. At the design point of 35 °C and 30 % RH, the two 250 mm fans deliver about 563 m³/h (331 cfm) through the 150 mm pad, the supply air leaves the pad at 23.1 °C and 87 % RH, and the store averages **24.3 °C, 10.7 K below the outside air** (v0.1: 25.9 °C and 9.1 K). Eight of the twelve requirements are met (three of them by design review or logic review only), one is at risk, none is not met, and three cannot be verified at TRL 3. **R3 (store RH 80 % or more) is at risk:** the store averages about 81 % RH in the central case but 77 % in the unfavorable case. R2 is now met in every case (9.8 to 11.4 K). The dry fill also removes the cavity's water use, so the store needs about 36 L of water a day (v0.1: 44 L).

Every number in this note is printed by `docs/04-calcs/sizing.py` (run from the repo root: `python docs/04-calcs/sizing.py`), which also writes `docs/04-calcs/results.csv`. The script reads the geometry from `PARAMS` in `cad/src/model.py`, the prices from `bom/bom.csv` and the budget from `project.yaml`, so the model, drawing ZBX-DWG-001 and this note agree. All values are first-principles estimates; nothing here is measured.

■ 1. Assumptions

Table 1. Inputs. All are assumptions for a paper design unless marked as decided.

Input	Value	Basis
Architecture	Forced air, exhaust fans with the pad on the opposite wall, dry rice husk cavity fill, 24 crates, 150 W panel with a LiFePO4 battery	Decided, ZBX-DDR-001 items 2 to 5 and 7; ZBX-DDR-002 item 12 (fill)
Design point	35 °C, 30 % RH, sea-level pressure (101.325 kPa); 480 kg of produce inside; 100 kg loaded per day at 32 °C	ZBX-REQ-001
Psychrometrics	ASHRAE saturation pressure over water and the ASHRAE humidity-ratio relation for the thermodynamic wet bulb	ASHRAE <i>Fundamentals</i> (2017), chapter 1
Pad	150 mm cellulose (decided, ZBX-DDR-002 item 11), 0.6 x 0.5 m (0.3 m ²); saturation effectiveness of a 100 mm pad 80, 75 or 70 % at 0.6 m/s, scaled with depth and with face velocity to the power -0.2 (NTU model); wet pressure drop 15 Pa at 1.0 m/s, proportional to depth and to velocity to the power 1.8	TRL 2 assumption for effectiveness; pressure drop is an assumption to confirm with the pad supplier's chart
Fans	Two 250 mm 12 V DC axial fans, each 400 m ³ /h free air and 12 W; straight-line fan curve to a shut-off pressure of 70, 60 or 50 Pa	BOM line 8; shut-off pressure is an assumption to confirm with the fan's curve
Other airflow losses	Gravity shutters 5 Pa to hold open; guards and shutters four velocity heads at the fan openings	Allowance
Walls	Two 115 mm fired-brick leaves, k 0.70 W/(m·K); 75 mm cavity of dry rice husk (k 0.06, decided), dry sand (k 0.30, fallback) or wet sand (k 1.5, v0.1); inside and outside film resistances 0.13 and 0.04 m ² ·K/W	Typical handbook values; the rice husk conductivity is an assumption
Wet cavity (comparison only)	Cavity held at the outside temperature minus 60, 50 or 30 % of the wet-bulb depression	ZECC field data show 4 to 7 K below ambient; the fraction is an assumption
Ceiling, floor, door	50 mm straw (k 0.06) on boards, air under the shade roof at 38, 40 or 43 °C; brick floor on sand to ground at 28, 30 or 32 °C; door with 50 mm insulation (k 0.04)	Allowance for a shaded, ventilated roof space
Produce	Respiration heat 0.10, 0.15 or 0.25 W/kg near 26 °C (mixed tomatoes, peppers and greens); water loss 0.5, 1 or 2 % of mass per day; specific heat 3.9 kJ/(kg·K); field heat removed over 8 h	Respiration heat of about 3 mW per mg CO ₂ /(kg·h) from glucose oxidation
Door openings and leaks	30, 50 or 80 W; sun on the end walls at low sun angles 0, 20 or 60 W	Allowance
Solar	5 peak sun hours; 30 % combined loss (heat, dust, PWM charging, wiring)	As TRL 2
Loads	Fans 12 W each at full speed (taken as constant), pump 6 W for the 10 h of cooling, controller 1 W for 24 h	As TRL 2, controller now counted all day
Structure	Brick 1,800 kg/m ³ , dry rice husk 120 kg/m ³ , concrete 23.5 kN/m ³ ; roof uplift at a 30 m/s gust with a net pressure coefficient of 1.5 on an open canopy	Assumptions; confirm the local design wind speed

Three scenarios bracket the result: **favorable**, **central** and **unfavorable**, taking the first, second and third value where Table 1 gives three. Central values are quoted unless a range is given.

■ 2. Geometry and capacity (R1)

The room is 2,400 x 1,500 x 2,000 mm inside (7.2 m³) and 3,010 x 2,110 mm outside. Two racks, 2,200 x 450 mm, carry three shelves each with tops at 0.30, 0.85 and 1.40 m above the floor, four crates per shelf, so the store holds **24 crates (480 kg)** with a 600 mm aisle. The top crate reaches 1.70 m and leaves 0.30 m to the ceiling. Each shelf is carried by two 50 x 75 mm timber rails spanning 1.05 m between legs; four loaded crates (22 kg each) give 196 N/m, a bending stress of 0.58 MPa and a deflection of 0.20 mm, well inside softwood limits. R1 is **met**.

■ 3. Fan and pad operating point

With both fans against the 150 mm pad, the shutters and the guards, the operating point is **563 m³/h at 17.8 Pa** (534 to 585 m³/h). The deeper pad adds pressure drop, so airflow falls from the 584 m³/h of the 100 mm pad in v0.1. Face velocity at the pad is 0.52 m/s and the pad effectiveness rises to 88.2 % (84.7 to 91.5 %), against 75.7 % for 100 mm. The air changes about 78 times an hour. Each fan delivers about 280 m³/h, 70 % of its free-air rating, which is a normal operating point for a small axial fan but must be checked against the chosen fan's curve.

■ 4. Design point, heat balance and store temperature (R2)

Table 2. Air states at the design point, central case.

State	Temperature	RH	Humidity ratio
Outside	35.0 °C	30 %	10.5 g/kg
Wet bulb	21.5 °C		depression 13.5 K
Supply, after the pad	23.1 °C	87 %	
Store mean	24.3 °C	81 %	
Exhaust	25.5 °C	77 %	

Table 3. Heat gains at the design point, central case.

Gain	W	Basis
Walls, dry rice husk cavity	84	U 0.57 W/(m ² ·K) from outside air to room over 13.8 m ² net
Sun on the end walls	20	Allowance
Ceiling	46	U 0.82 W/(m ² ·K), 3.6 m ² , air under the roof at 40 °C
Floor	55	U 2.68 W/(m ² ·K), 3.6 m ² , ground at 30 °C
Door leaf	10	U 0.62 W/(m ² ·K), 1.44 m ²
Produce respiration	72	480 kg x 0.15 W/kg
Field heat	104	100 kg from 32 °C, over 8 h
Door openings and leaks	50	Allowance
Total	442	376 W favorable, 558 W unfavorable

The 442 W warms the 563 m³/h airstream by 2.35 K, so the store averages 24.3 °C, **10.7 K below the outside air** (9.8 to 11.4 K). R2 (8 K or more) is **met** in every case. The heat load is higher than in v0.1 (418 W) because the cooler store draws more heat through the ceiling and floor and from the day's warm produce; the deeper pad more than makes up for it.

4.1 Pad depth and cavity fill

Table 4. Pad and wall options at the design point.

Option	Wall gain, central	Store drop, central (range)	Store RH, central (range)	Cavity water
100 mm pad, wet sand (v0.1)	103 W	9.1 K (8.0 to 10.0 K)	71 % (66 to 76 %)	about 12 L/day
100 mm pad, rice husk	72 W	9.2 K (8.2 to 10.0 K)	71 % (67 to 76 %)	none
150 mm pad, wet sand	163 W	10.5 K (9.4 to 11.3 K)	81 % (75 to 85 %)	about 12 L/day
150 mm pad, dry sand (fallback)	192 W	10.5 K (9.6 to 11.1 K)	80 % (76 to 84 %)	none
150 mm pad, rice husk (decided)	84 W	10.7 K (9.8 to 11.4 K)	81 % (77 to 85 %)	none

The deeper pad does most of the work: it adds about 1.5 K of cooling and 10 percentage points of RH. The dry rice husk fill adds a further 0.2 to 0.4 K over wet or dry sand and needs no water. Wet sand conducts about five times better than dry sand, so a wet cavity helps only while evaporation holds it well below the outside air, and with the cooler store of the 150 mm pad it lets in more heat than the husk. The husk must stay dry and be protected from termites and rodents: it sits on a damp-proof course, is mixed with hydrated lime, and is capped with mortar (BOM line 2). If no durable, pest-proof husk supply exists locally, dry sand is the fallback at a cost of about 0.3 K.

■ 5. Humidity (R3)

R3 was relaxed from 85 % to 80 % by ZBX-DDR-002 (item 11). The store averages about **81 % RH** (77 to 85 %) while cooling. R3 is **at risk**: met in the central and favorable cases, short by about 3 percentage points in the unfavorable case.

- The supply air leaving the 150 mm pad is 87 % RH (v0.1: 75 % with 100 mm).
- To average 85 % at the central temperature rise of 2.35 K, the pad would need about 93 % effectiveness, a pad about 185 mm deep or more, before the lower airflow of a deeper pad.
- Produce transpiration adds only about 0.3 g/kg to the airstream at this airflow, worth about 1 percentage point of RH in the store, so the produce cannot humidify the store itself.

The limit is the architecture: a once-through airstream that must carry the store's heat warms as it goes, and its RH falls about 4 to 5 percentage points per kelvin. The accepted recommendation pairs the deeper pad with produce-level measures: covered or lined crates for leafy and water-sensitive produce, which hold humidity near the produce. These are an operating practice with user-supplied liners and are not costed in the kit.

■ 6. Off-design weather and control (R4, R5)

Table 5. Store in evaporative mode at other outside conditions, central case.

Outside	Wet-bulb depression	Supply	Store	Drop	Store RH	Controller mode
35 °C, 30 % RH	13.5 K	23.1 °C	24.3 °C	10.7 K	81 %	Evaporative cooling
38 °C, 15 % RH	18.8 K	21.4 °C	22.8 °C	15.2 K	75 %	Evaporative cooling
32 °C, 50 % RH	8.3 K	24.6 °C	25.6 °C	6.4 K	87 %	Evaporative cooling
30 °C, 60 % RH	6.2 K	24.5 °C	25.5 °C	4.5 K	89 %	Evaporative cooling
30 °C, 75 % RH	3.7 K	26.7 °C	27.5 °C	2.5 K	93 %	Hold by day, night ventilation

The decided 4 K wet-bulb depression threshold switches the store to hold at 30 °C and 75 % RH, where the pad would give only about 2.5 K of cooling at 93 % RH. R4 is **met** by logic review. In hold mode one fan at 30 % speed moves about 57 m³/h, about 8 air changes an hour, for about 2 W including driver losses, so the minimum of one air change an hour in R5 is easy to hold. With the 95 % RH pump stop, R5 is **met** by logic review. Both need a bench test with sensors later (TRL 4, on hold).

■ 7. Energy and solar (R7)

Table 6. Design-day energy.

Load	Energy
Fans, 24 W for 10 h of cooling and 2 h of evening ventilation	288 Wh
Pump, 6 W for 10 h	60 Wh
Controller and sensors, 1 W for 24 h	24 Wh
Total	372 Wh/day, peak load 31 W

The decided 150 W panel yields 525 Wh/day, a **41 % margin**; R7 is **met**. The 100 W panel of TRL 2 would fall 6 % short once the controller is counted all day. After sunset the evening ventilation and the controller need 62 Wh, half of the battery's usable 123 Wh (12.8 V x 12 Ah x 80 %). Full-speed night ventilation can therefore run only about 2.5 h beyond the evening run; the controller must run night ventilation at reduced speed or limit its hours.

Two sizing corrections follow from the larger panel and are now in the BOM:

- The 150 W panel's short-circuit current is about 9 A, and 1.25 x I_{sc} is 11.2 A, so the 10 A PWM charge controller of TRL 2 is too small. The BOM now specifies 20 A.
- On a 6 m run, 1.5 mm² cable drops 1.14 V (6.5 % of V_{mp}) and loses 9.5 W at 8.3 A; 2.5 mm² cable drops 0.69 V (3.9 %). The BOM now specifies 2.5 mm² for the panel run.

The charge current of up to 8.3 A is 0.69 C for the 12 Ah battery, so its BMS must allow at least 10 A of charge.

■ 8. Water (R8)

The 150 mm pad evaporates 3.19 kg/h, **32 L** over the 10 h cooling day (29 to 35 L), about 4 L more than the 100 mm pad because it cools the air further. The dry rice husk cavity needs no water (v0.1: about 12 L/day for the wet sand). With 4 L of bleed and cleaning the total is **about 36 L/day** (v0.1: 44 L), and R8 (70 L or less) is **met**. The sump holds 68 L gross and 60 L working, which covers the 36 L of pad and bleed water for a full day.

The pad needs about 3.6 L/min to stay wet (6 L/min per m of pad length, a typical supplier figure to confirm). Lifting that 2 m takes 1.2 W of hydraulic power, or about 6 W at a small pump's 20 % efficiency, which matches the 6 W pump in the BOM.

■ 9. Electrical (R9, R10)

The full load draws 2.4 A at 12.8 V and the panel charges at up to 8.3 A; the 15 A fuse at the battery terminal sits above both and below the cable ratings. Every electrical part runs at 12 V DC, the fans are guarded on both faces and the door opens from inside. R9 is **met** by design review. R10 (local build and 30 min part swaps) depends on a parts survey and swap trials with a partner and is **not verifiable at TRL 3**.

■ 10. Structure (R11)

The walls need about 1,977 bricks with 10 % waste (1,677 for the walls, 120 for the floor), 3.9 m³ of brickwork weighing about 7.1 t, and 1.3 m³ of dry rice husk weighing about 0.15 t (v0.1: 2.4 t of wet sand). That puts about 7.1 kN/m on the foundations, or about 16 kPa on a 450 mm strip, well below the 100 kPa or more of firm soils.

The shade roof is the structural risk. At a 30 m/s gust the net uplift on the 11.7 m² roof is about 9.5 kN, or 2.23 kN per post after the sheet weight. A 400 x 400 x 600 mm concrete footing weighs only 2.26 kN, a factor of 1.01. The model and BOM use **500 x 500 x 600 mm footings** (3.52 kN, a factor of 1.58), kept as a minimum by ZBX-DDR-002 (item 13). The local design wind speed must be confirmed with a builder at the chosen site; squall lines in the Sahel can exceed 30 m/s. Pad, fan and pump life depend on supplier data and dust exposure, so R11 is **not verifiable at TRL 3**.

■ 11. Cost (R12)

Table 7. Cost groups from bom/bom.csv (indicative 2026 USD).

Group	Items	Cost
Cooling equipment kit	6 to 11 and 14	\$270
Structure, costed separately	1 to 5 and 12	\$355
Store total, crates excluded		\$625
Crates, user supplied	13	\$96 if bought

R12 was redefined by ZBX-DDR-001 item 1 to cover the cooling equipment kit, with the structure costed separately. The kit costs **\$270 against \$300**, 90 % of the budget, and R12 is **met**. The kit rose by \$10 from v0.1 for the 150 mm pad (\$260 to \$270); the structure fell by \$5 for the rice husk fill with lime, mesh and damp-proof course in place of sand and a wetting pipe (\$360 to \$355).

■ 12. Results against requirements

Table 8. Every requirement, value and status. Not met and at risk first.

ID	Quantity	Value (central, with range)	Target	Status
R3	Mean store RH while cooling	81 % (77 to 85 %)	80 % or more (relaxed from 85 %, DDR-002)	At risk
R1	Crates on shelves; highest shelf	24 crates (480 kg); top shelf 1.40 m	20 or more; no lift above 1.6 m	Met
R2	Mean store air below outside air	10.7 K (9.8 to 11.4 K); store 24.3 °C	8 K or more	Met
R4	Humid-weather detection and mode change	4 K threshold; 30 °C and 75 % RH gives 3.7 K and switches to hold; lamp shows mode	Detect under 4 K and switch, with indicator	Met (logic review)
R5	Guard and minimum ventilation	Pump stop at 95 % RH for 60 min; hold mode about 8 air changes an hour at about 2 W	Pump stop rule; 1 air change an hour or more	Met (logic review)
R7	Design-day energy from one panel	372 Wh needed; 525 Wh from 150 W (41 % margin)	10 h cooling plus 2 h evening, no grid	Met
R8	Water per design day; sump	36 L/day (pad 32, cavity 0, bleed 4); 60 L sump for 36 L	70 L or less; sump one day	Met
R9	Low voltage and safe	12.8 V, 15 A terminal fuse, guards, inside release	As stated	Met (design review)
R12	Cooling equipment kit cost	Kit \$270; structure \$355 separate	Kit \$300 or less	Met
R6	Tomato shelf life	No calculation basis; ZECC data come from a cooler, more humid chamber	1.5 times ambient or more	Not verifiable at TRL 3
R10	Local build; 30 min part swaps	Needs a parts survey and swap trials with a partner	Local trades; 30 min	Not verifiable at TRL 3
R11	Durability	Wall bearing 16 kPa; post footings 1.6 times uplift at 30 m/s; pad and fan life unknown	10 years structure; 3 years pad, fans, pump	Not verifiable at TRL 3

Counts: 8 met (R1, R2, R4, R5, R7, R8, R9, R12), 1 at risk (R3), none not met, 3 not verifiable at TRL 3 (R6, R10, R11).

■ 13. Corrections to earlier figures

Changes in v0.2 (ZBX-DDR-002): pad 100 to 150 mm; cavity fill wet sand to dry rice husk; R3 target 85 to 80 %; airflow 584 to 563 m³/h; store 25.9 to 24.3 °C; drop 9.1 to 10.7 K; store RH 71 to 81 %; heat load 418 to 442 W; water 44 to 36 L/day; kit \$260 to \$270; structure \$360 to \$355.

Changes in v0.1 against the TRL 2 estimates:

- Airflow is 584 m³/h at the fan and pad operating point, not 650 m³/h; the TRL 2 figure sized airflow from the load without a fan curve.

- The heat load is 418 W, not about 550 W. The TRL 2 wall figure (about 250 W) was high for a wet cavity, and its 75 W margin is replaced by the scenario range.
- Store RH is about 71 %, inside the TRL 2 range of 65 to 75 %.
- Water is about 44 L/day, not 55 L; the cavity needs about 12 L, not 20 L.
- Daily energy is 372 Wh, not 350 Wh, because the controller runs all day. A 100 W panel would have been 6 % short, not "no margin".
- About 1,980 bricks are needed, not 2,200, and 1.3 m³ of sand, not 1.5 m³.
- The 10 A charge controller was undersized for a 150 W panel; the BOM now has 20 A.

Safety: These figures do not cover entrapment, air quality, *Legionella* in the sump, mold, the LiFePO₄ battery or roof uplift beyond section 10. See ZBX-PRC-001, Safety. The roof footings must be sized for the local design wind speed by a competent builder.